

NumPy



NumPy – huh, yeah – what’s it good for?

- NumPy introduces a new data structure: **the array**

An array is a regular, N-dimensional grid of data of the same type, typically numerical data

- Great for storing homogeneous data, where every element in the array has the same meaning. E.g. images, sound, time series



Efficient machine-native implementation

- Data is stored in a contiguous chunk of memory, using machine-native data types
- Separate metadata tells numpy how to interpret that memory as an array

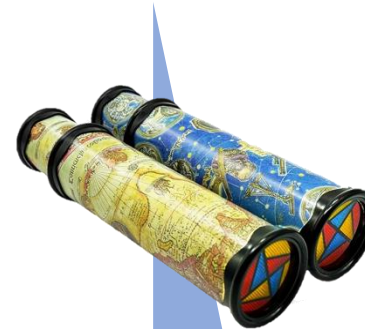
Memory block storage

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---

int64
8 bytes

NumPy array metadata

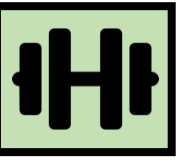
dtype	int64
ndim	2
shape	(3, 3)
strides	(24, 8)

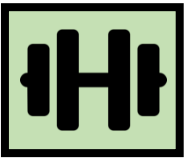


NumPy view

0	1	2
3	4	5
6	7	8

Is NumPy any better than a list-of-lists?





Is NumPy any better than a list-of-lists?

- NumPy arrays are implemented using machine-native data types, which means that common operations and algorithms can be implemented with less per-element overhead, making them faster than a Python list-of-lists
- Faster in what sense?
- **It's not going to scale any better than list-of-lists**
Scaling complexity is the same. E.g., square matrix multiplication is still $O(N^3)$
- **Much faster for fixed-size problems**
- This speed advantage strictly depends on operations being made in C and Fortran. Avoid Python for-loops and use existing NumPy and SciPy functionality!

* The best matrix multiplication algorithm as of 2025 scales as $O(n^{2.371339})$. However, out-of-the-box NumPy packages usually use a Fortran library called OpenBLAS that implements a $O(n^3)$ algorithm

Same data, different views

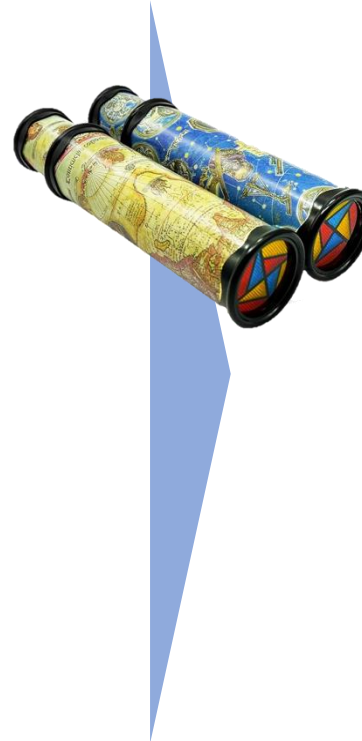
Memory block storage

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---

int64
8 bytes

NumPy array metadata

dtype	int64
ndim	2
shape	(3, 3)
strides	(24, 8)



NumPy view

0	1	2
3	4	5
6	7	8

Same data, different views

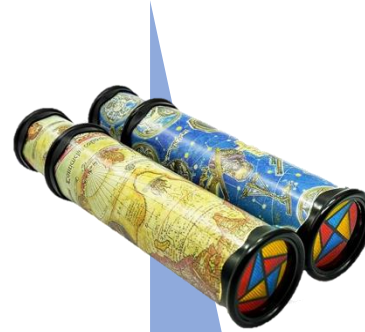
Memory block storage

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---

int64
8 bytes

NumPy array metadata

dtype	int64
ndim	1
shape	(9,)
strides	(8,)



NumPy view

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---

O(1) operations in NumPy

Memory block

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	----	----	----

When NumPy can execute a command by just changing the metadata, it does. The result is a **new view of the same data in memory**

NumPy operation

`x`

NumPy array metadata

ndim	2
shape	(4, 3)
strides	(24, 8)

NumPy view

0	1	2
3	4	5
6	7	8
9	10	11

`x.ravel()`

ndim	1
shape	(12,)
strides	(8,)

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11
---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	----	----

`x.T`

ndim	2
shape	(3, 4)
strides	(8, 24)

0	3	6	9
1	4	7	10
2	5	8	11

`x.reshape((2, 6))`

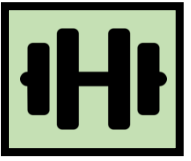
ndim	2
shape	(2, 6)
strides	(48, 8)

0	1	2	3	4	5
6	7	8	9	10	11

The golden rule of NumPy

Operations that can be executed by only changing the metadata return a **“view”** of the original data memory block

In all other cases, it creates a **“copy”** with a new data memory block



Views vs. copies in indexing operations

Memory block

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	----	----	----

NumPy operation

x

NumPy array metadata

dtype	int64
ndim	2
shape	(4, 3)
strides	(24, 8)

0	1	2
3	4	5
6	7	8
9	10	11

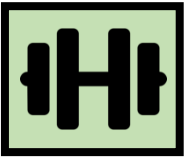
Slicing

x[::3, ::2]

dtype	
ndim	
shape	
strides	

0	2
9	11

Can this operation be done just by changing the metadata?



Views vs. copies in indexing operations

Memory block

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	----	----	----

NumPy operation

x

NumPy array metadata

dtype	int64
ndim	2
shape	(4, 3)
strides	(24, 8)

0	1	2
3	4	5
6	7	8
9	10	11

Slicing

x[::3, ::2]

dtype	int64
ndim	2
shape	(2, 2)
strides	(72, 16)

0	2
9	11

Can this operation be done just
by changing the metadata?
YES!

Can it be done for all slicing
operations?

Views vs. copies in indexing operations

Memory block

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	----	----	----

NumPy operation

x

NumPy array metadata

Slicing always returns
a **view** of the original array

Slicing

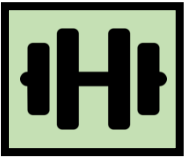
x[::3, ::2]

dtype	int64
ndim	2
shape	(2, 2)
strides	(72, 16)

0	2
9	11

Can this operation be done just
by changing the metadata?
YES!

Can it be done for all slicing
operations?
YES!



Views vs. copies in indexing operations

Memory block

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	----	----	----

NumPy operation

x

NumPy array metadata

dtype	int64
ndim	2
shape	(4, 3)
strides	(24, 8)

0	1	2
3	4	5
6	7	8
9	10	11

Fancy indexing

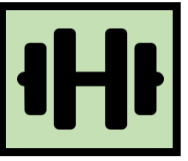
x[[0, 3, 2], [1, 1, 2]]

row indices column indices

dtype	
ndim	
shape	
strides	

1	10	8
---	----	---

Can this operation be done just by changing the metadata?



View vs copies in indexing operations

Memory block

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	----	----	----

NumPy operation

NumPy array metadata

x

Fancy indexing always returns
a **copy** of the original array

Fancy indexing

x[[0, 3, 2], [1, 1, 2]]

row indices column indices

dtype	int64
ndim	1
shape	(3,)
strides	???

1	10	8
---	----	---

Can this operation be done just
by changing the metadata?
NO!

A special kind of view: broadcasting operations

Memory block

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---

NumPy array metadata

dtype	int64
ndim	2
shape	(4, 9)
strides	(0, 8)

The shape says we have 4 rows and 9 columns

A stride of 0 means that for each new row, we don't move in memory

A special kind of view: broadcasting operations

Memory block

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---

NumPy array metadata

dtype	int64
ndim	2
shape	(4, 9)
strides	(0, 8)

The shape says we have 4 rows and 9 columns

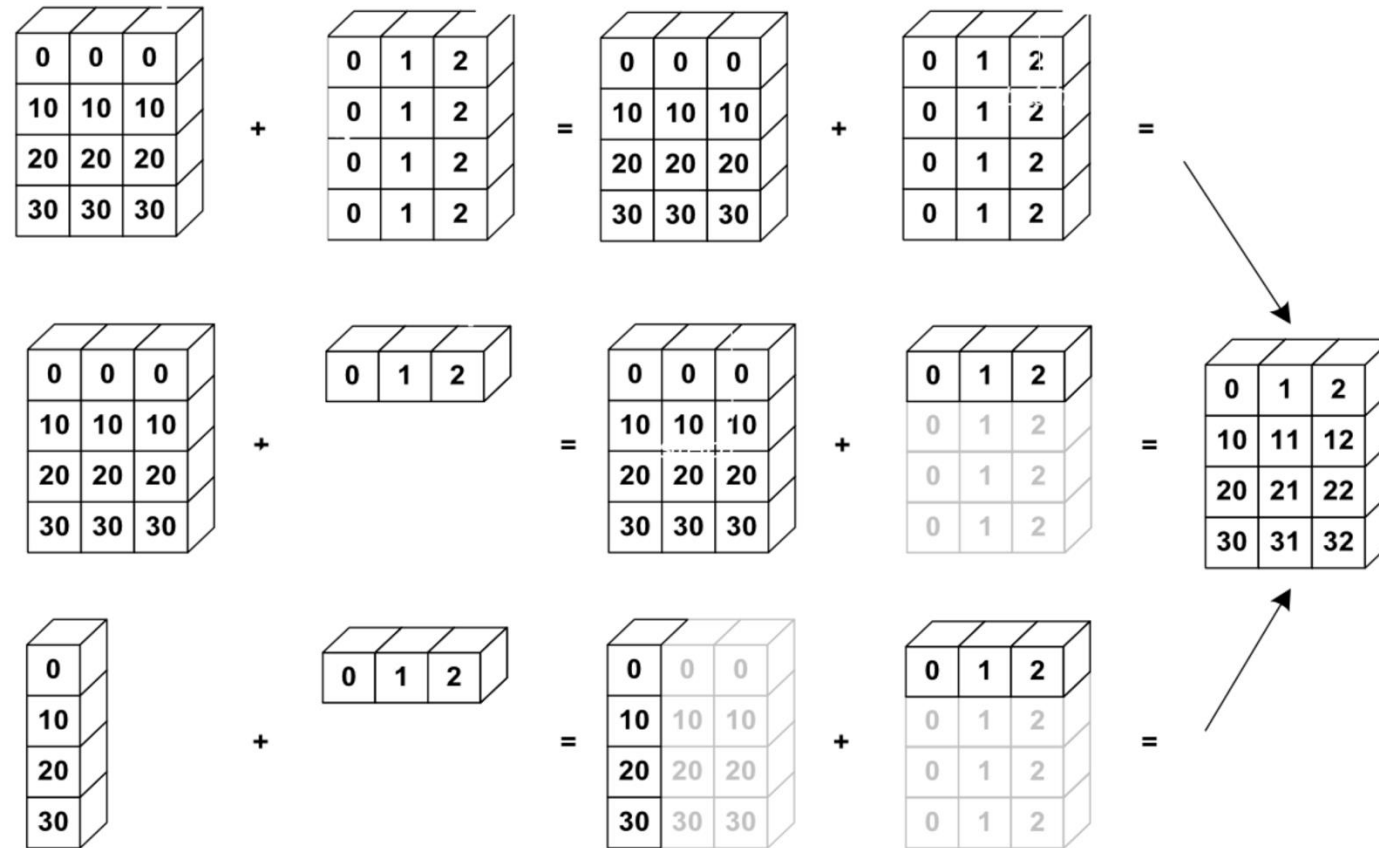
A stride of 0 means that for each new row, we don't move in memory

As a result, we obtain a view with duplicated rows, without using extra memory!

NumPy view

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8

NumPy uses broadcasting to perform operation on arrays of different shape without having to allocate extra memory



View or copy? Quiz



Exercise

```
exercises/numpy_view_or_copy/  
view_or_copy_interactive.ipynb
```

Setting up a pet shop



Live Coding

notebooks/020_numpy/
015_assignment_by_reference.ipynb

Python assignment is “by reference”

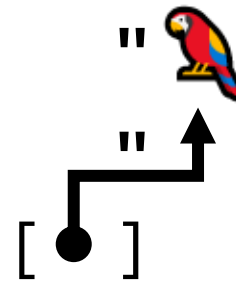
```
cage = ["🦜"]
```

Global
namespace

Memory

Final result

cage



= ["🦜"]

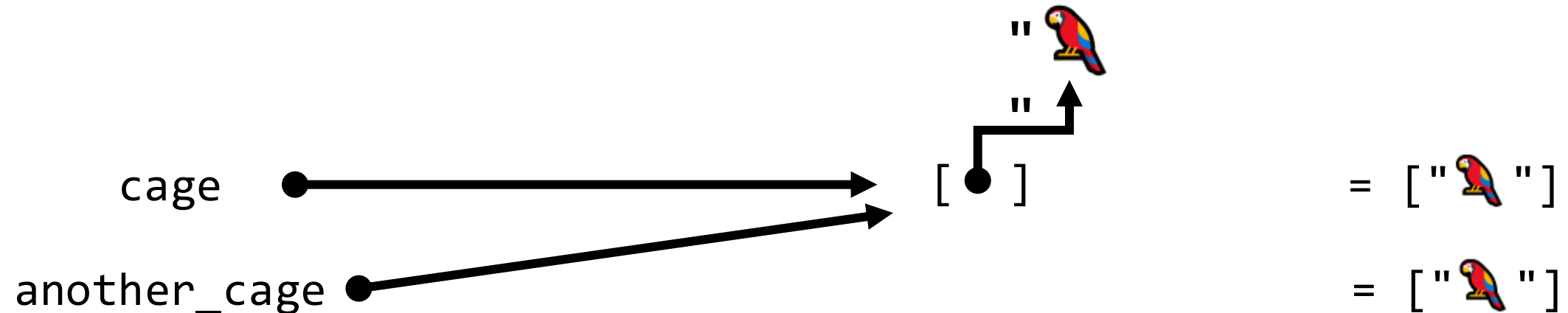
Python assignment is “by reference”

```
cage = ["🦜"]  
another_cage = cage
```

Global
namespace

Memory

Final result



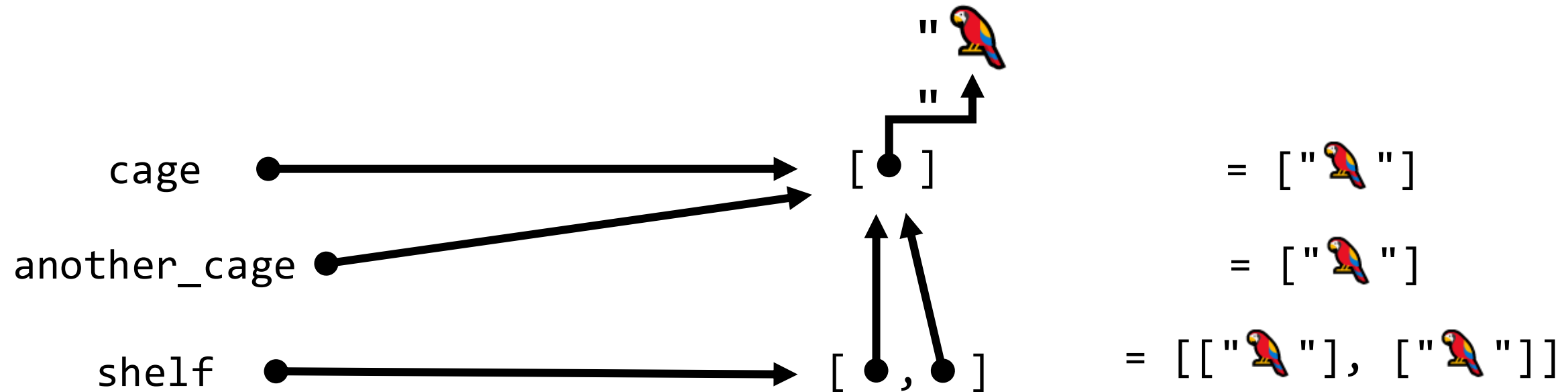
Python assignment is “by reference”

```
cage = ["🦜"]  
another_cage = cage  
shelf = [cage, cage]
```

Global
namespace

Memory

Final result



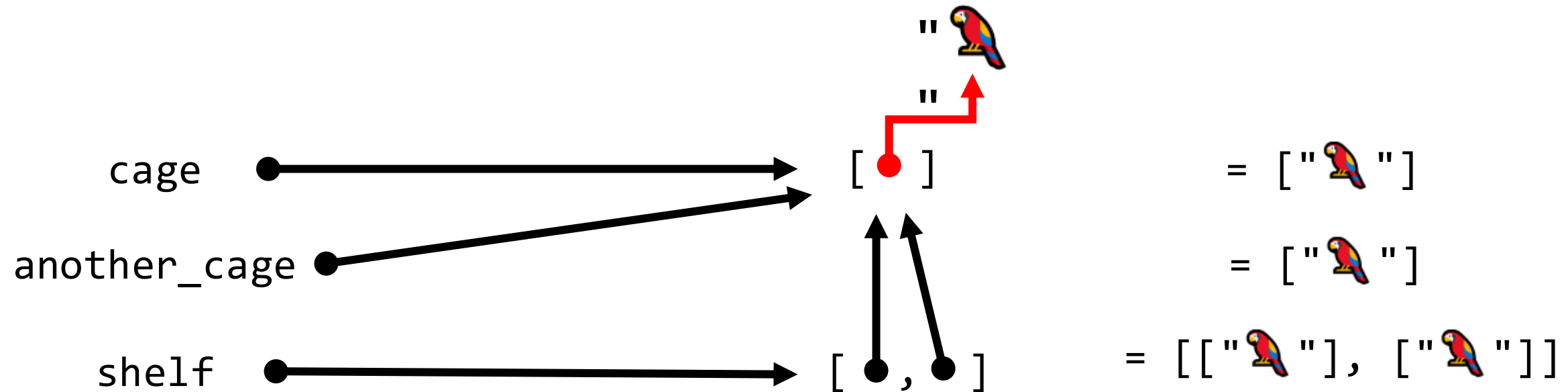
Python assignment is “by reference”

```
cage = ["🦜"]  
another_cage = cage  
shelf = [cage, cage]  
cage[0]
```

Global
namespace

Memory

Final result



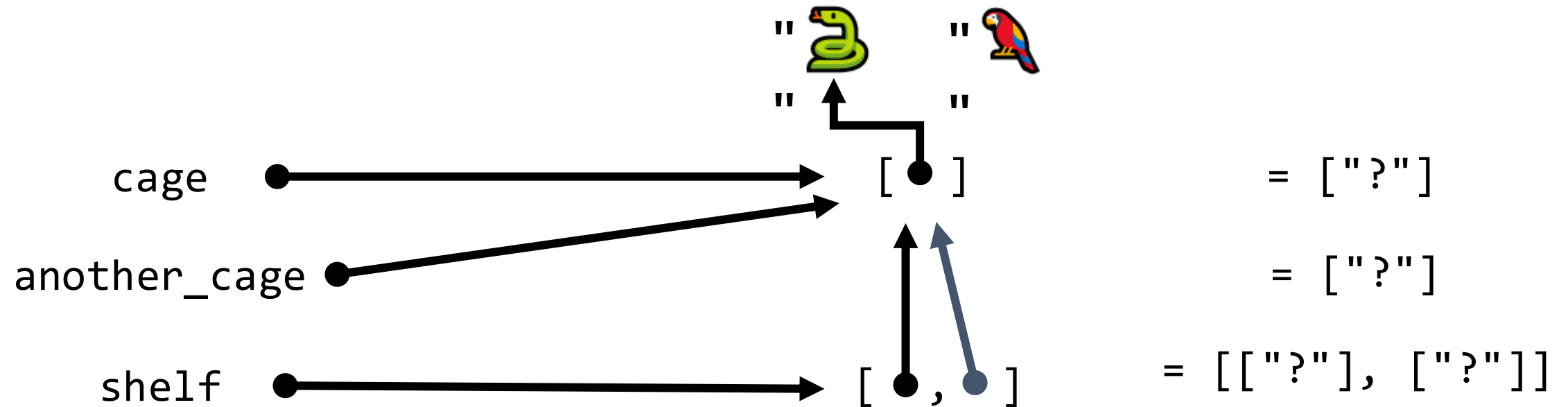
Python assignment is “by reference”

```
cage = ["🦜"]  
another_cage = cage  
shelf = [cage, cage]  
cage[0] = "🐍"
```

Global
namespace

Memory

Final result



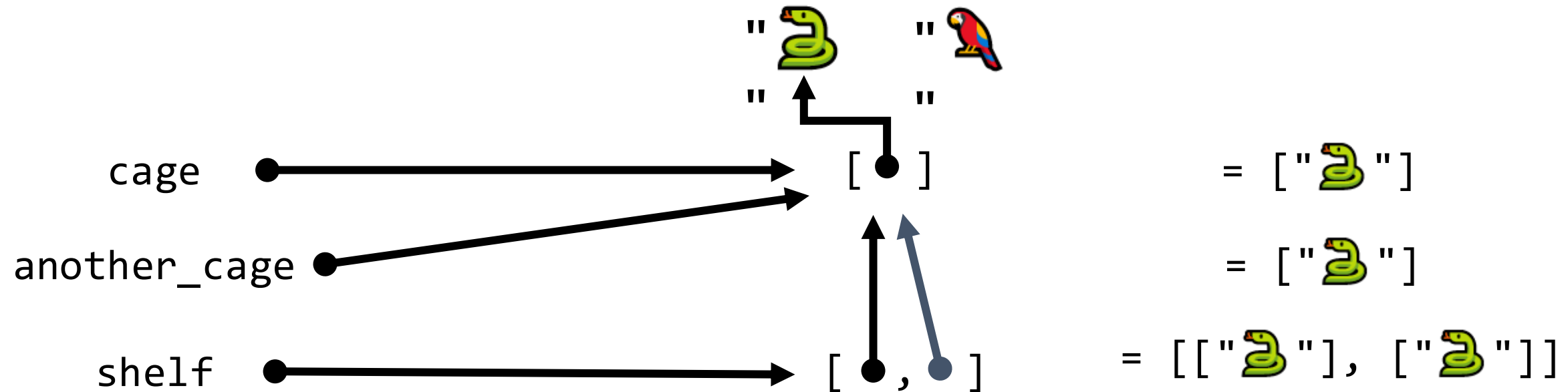
Python assignment is “by reference”

```
cage = ["🦜"]  
another_cage = cage  
shelf = [cage, cage]  
cage[0] = "🐍"
```

Global
namespace

Memory

Final result



Changing one view changes them all

```
x = np.arange(12).reshape(4,3)
```

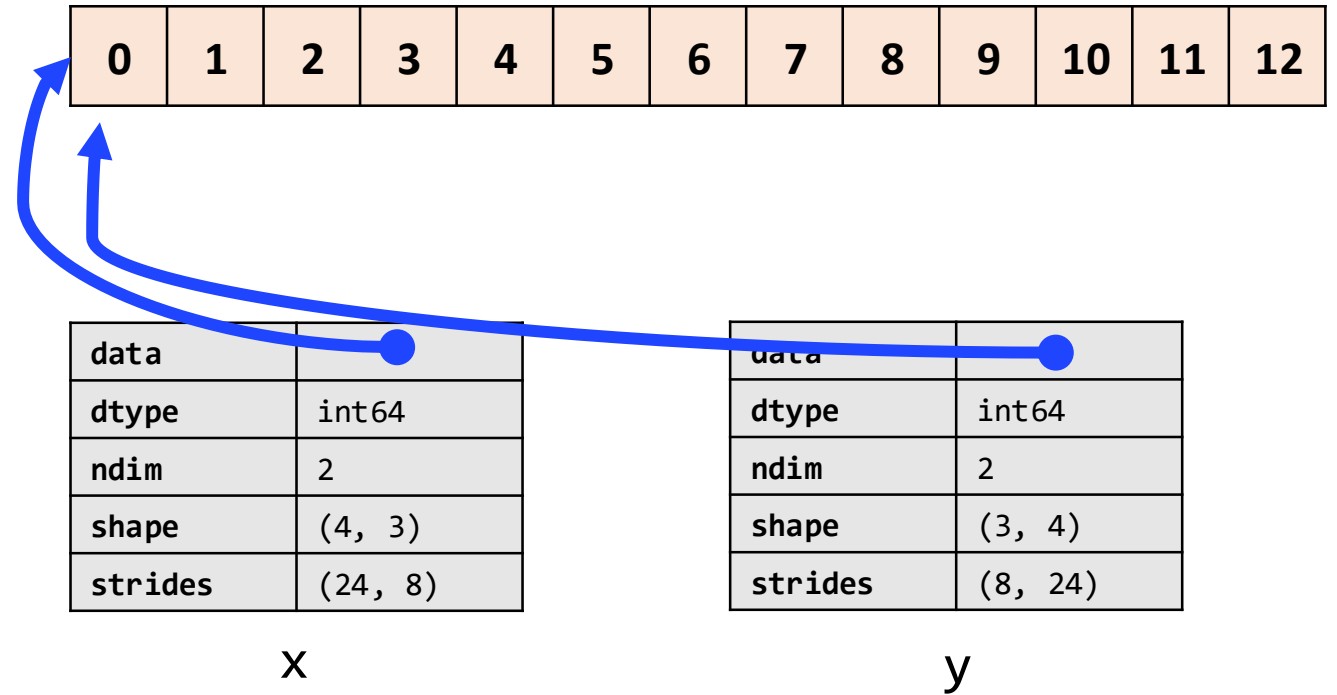
```
x
```

```
array([[ 0,  1,  2],  
       [ 3,  4,  5],  
       [ 6,  7,  8],  
       [ 9, 10, 11]])
```

```
y = x.T
```

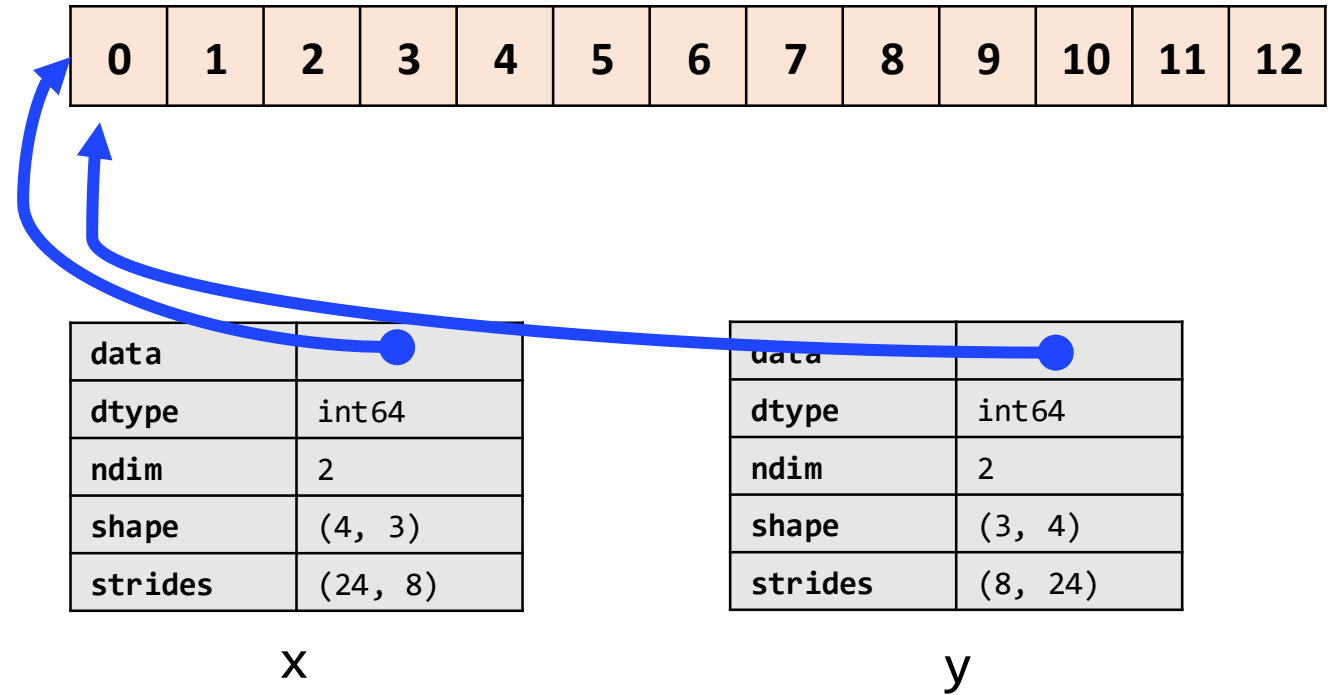
```
y
```

```
array([[ 0,  3,  6,  9],  
       [ 1,  4,  7, 10],  
       [ 2,  5,  8, 11]])
```



Changing one view changes them all

```
y[0, 0] = 13
```



Changing one view changes them all

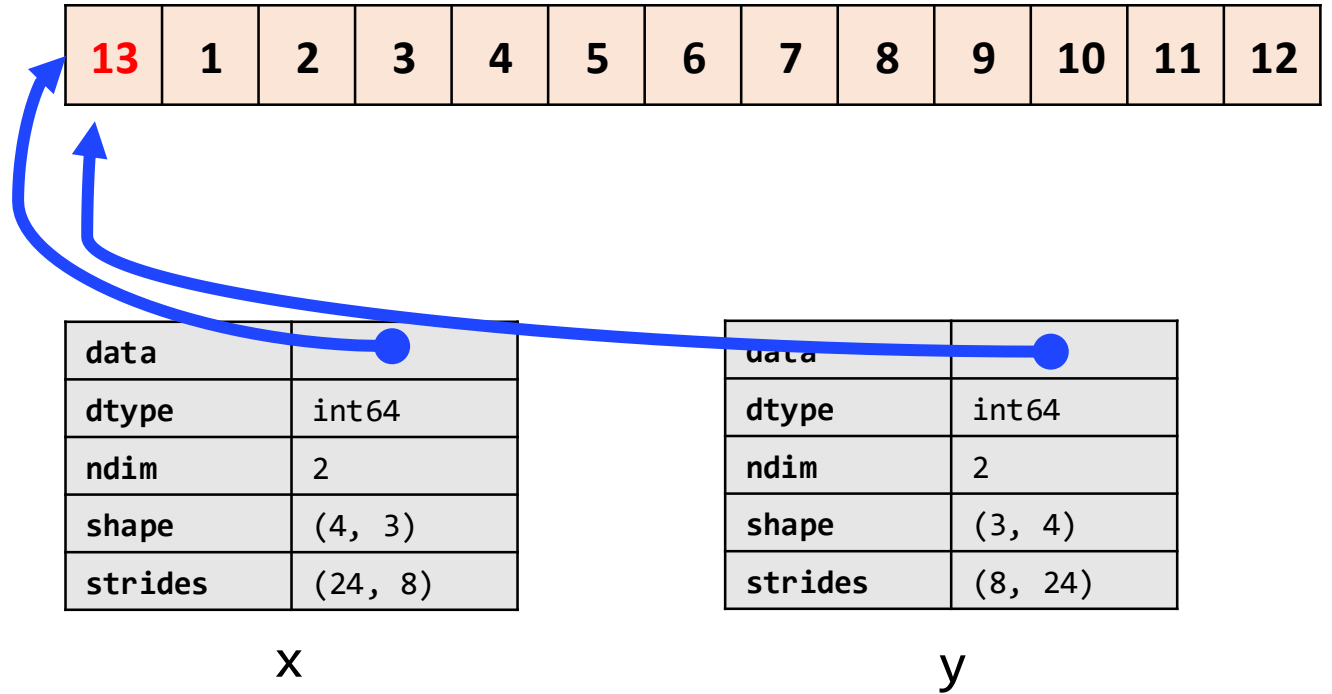
```
y[0, 0] = 13
```

```
y
```

```
array([[13,  3,  6,  9],  
       [ 1,  4,  7, 10],  
       [ 2,  5,  8, 11]])
```

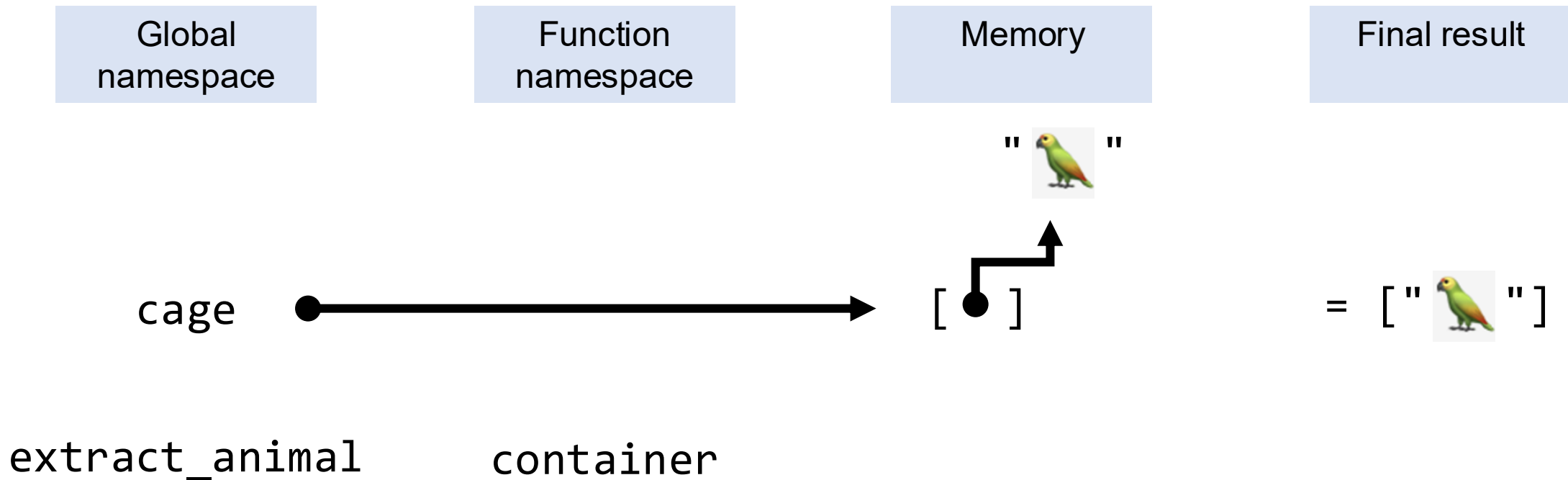
```
x
```

```
array([[13,  1,  2],  
       [ 3,  4,  5],  
       [ 6,  7,  8],  
       [ 9, 10, 11]])
```



Passing an argument is an assignment

```
cage = ["🦜"]  
def extract_animal(container):  
    return container.pop()
```



Passing an argument is an assignment

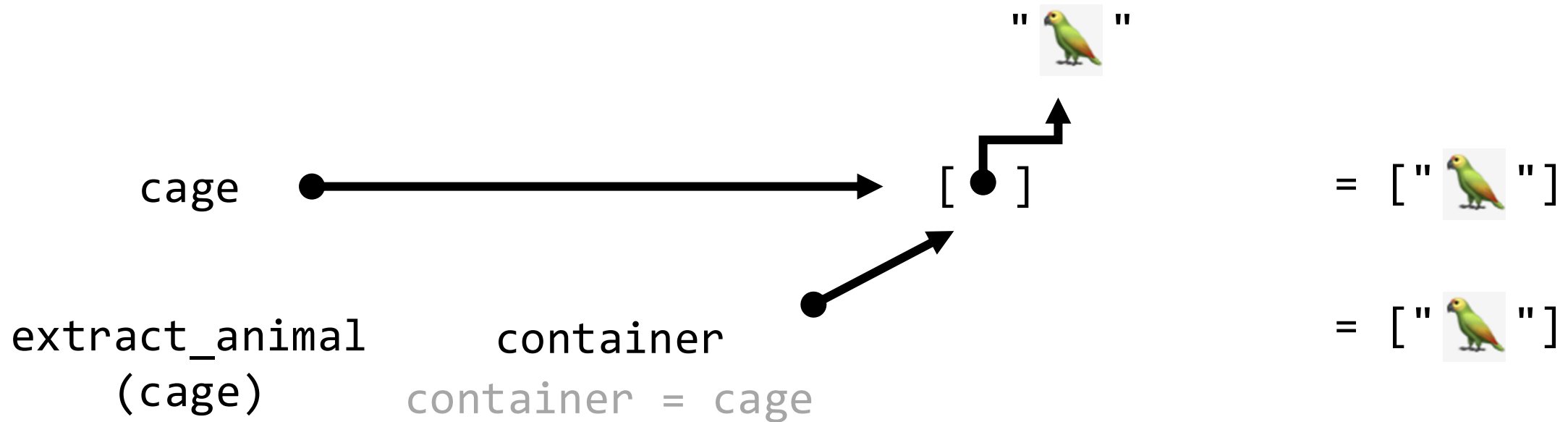
```
cage = ["🦜"]  
def extract_animal(container):  
    return container.pop()  
extract_animal(cage)
```

Global
namespace

Function
namespace

Memory

Final result



Passing an argument is an assignment

```
cage = ["🦜"]  
def extract_animal(container):  
    return container.pop()  
extract_animal(cage)
```

Global
namespace

Function
namespace

Memory

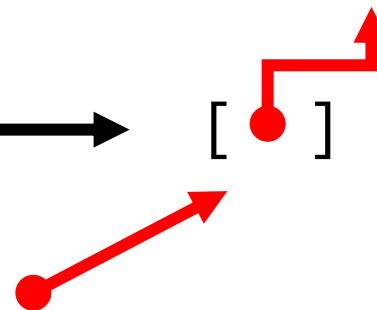
Final result

" 🦜 "

cage



[]



extract_animal
(cage)

container

container.pop()

= [" 🦜 "]

= [" 🦜 "]

Passing an argument is an assignment

```
cage = ["🦜"]  
def extract_animal(container):  
    return container.pop()  
extract_animal(cage)
```

Global
namespace

Function
namespace

Memory

Final result

"🦜"

cage



[]

= ["?"]

extract_animal
(cage)

container

container.pop()



= []

Passing an argument is an assignment

```
cage = ["🦜"]  
def extract_animal(container):  
    return container.pop()  
extract_animal(cage)
```

Global
namespace

Function
namespace

Memory

Final result

"🦜"

cage



[]

= []

extract_animal
(cage)

container

container.pop()



= []

Assignments and functions



Exercise

`exercises/numpy_assignments/
side_effects.ipynb`

Put up the GREEN sign after you solve part A

Careful with your functions

```
def robust_log(x, cte=1e-10):  
    """ Compute the log of the elements of an array.  
  
    Values that are equal to 0.0 in `x` are substituted with a tiny constant `cte`  
    to avoid a divide-by-zero warning, and `-inf` values in the output arrays.  
    """  
    x[x == 0] = cte  
    return np.log(x)
```

Careful with your functions

```
def robust_log(x, cte=1e-10):  
    """ Compute the log of the elements of an array.
```

```
    Values that are equal to 0.0 in `x` are substituted with a tiny constant `cte`  
    to avoid a divide-by-zero warning, and `-inf` values in the output arrays.  
    """
```

```
    x[x == 0] = cte  
    return np.log(x)
```

```
a = np.array([[0.3, 0.01], [0, 1]])  
print(a)
```

```
[[0.3  0.01]  
 [0.   1.   ]]
```

```
# Using the NumPy's log directly  
np.log(a)
```

```
/tmp/ipykernel_50294/3282750587.py:2: RuntimeWarning: divide by zero encountered in log  
np.log(a)
```

```
array([[ -1.2039728 , -4.60517019],  
       [      -inf,    0.         ]])
```

```
# Our function handles values equal zero to return a small value  
robust_log(a)
```

```
array([[ -1.2039728 , -4.60517019],  
       [-23.02585093,    0.         ]])
```

Careful with your functions

```
def robust_log(x, cte=1e-10):  
    """ Compute the log of the elements of an array.  
  
    Values that are equal to 0.0 in `x` are substituted with a tiny constant `cte`  
    to avoid a divide-by-zero warning, and `-inf` values in the output arrays.  
    """  
    x[x == 0] = cte  
    return np.log(x)
```

```
a = np.array([[0.3, 0.01], [0, 1]])  
b = a[1, :] # A view of `a`  
print(b)
```

```
[0. 1.]
```

```
robust_log(b)
```

```
array([-23.02585093,  0.          ])
```

```
b
```

```
array([1.e-10, 1.e+00])
```

```
a
```

```
array([[3.e-01, 1.e-02],  
       [1.e-10, 1.e+00]])
```



The input array has been modified!

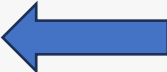


... and so have all other views
of the same data!

Careful with your functions

Best practice: functions that take an array as an input should avoid modifying it in place!
Always make a copy or be super extra clear in the docstring

```
def robust_log(x, cte=1e-10):  
    """ Compute the log of the elements of an array.  
  
    Values that are equal to 0.0 in `x` are substituted with a tiny constant `cte`  
    to avoid a divide-by-zero warning, and `-inf` values in the output arrays.  
    """  
    x = x.copy()  
    x[x == 0] = cte  
    return np.log(x)
```



NumPy views and copies summary

View

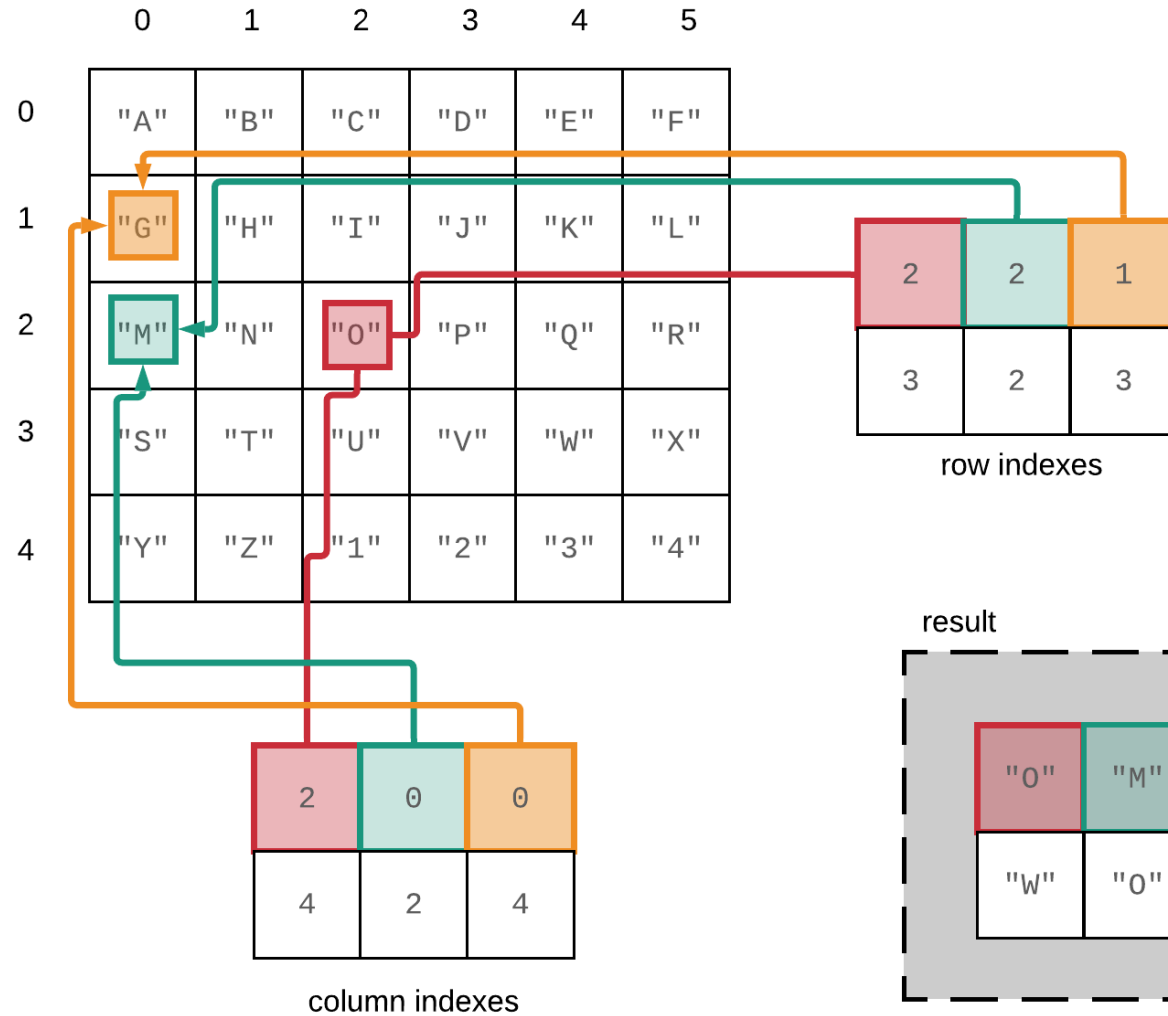
- There can be multiple views of the same memory block, interpreted as different arrays
- Slicing returns a view
- In-place operations on a view modify the memory block and all of its views

Copy

- When a copy of an array needs to be created, it allocates a separate memory block and associates it with new metadata
- Fancy indexing always returns copies
- A copy can be forced with `.copy()`

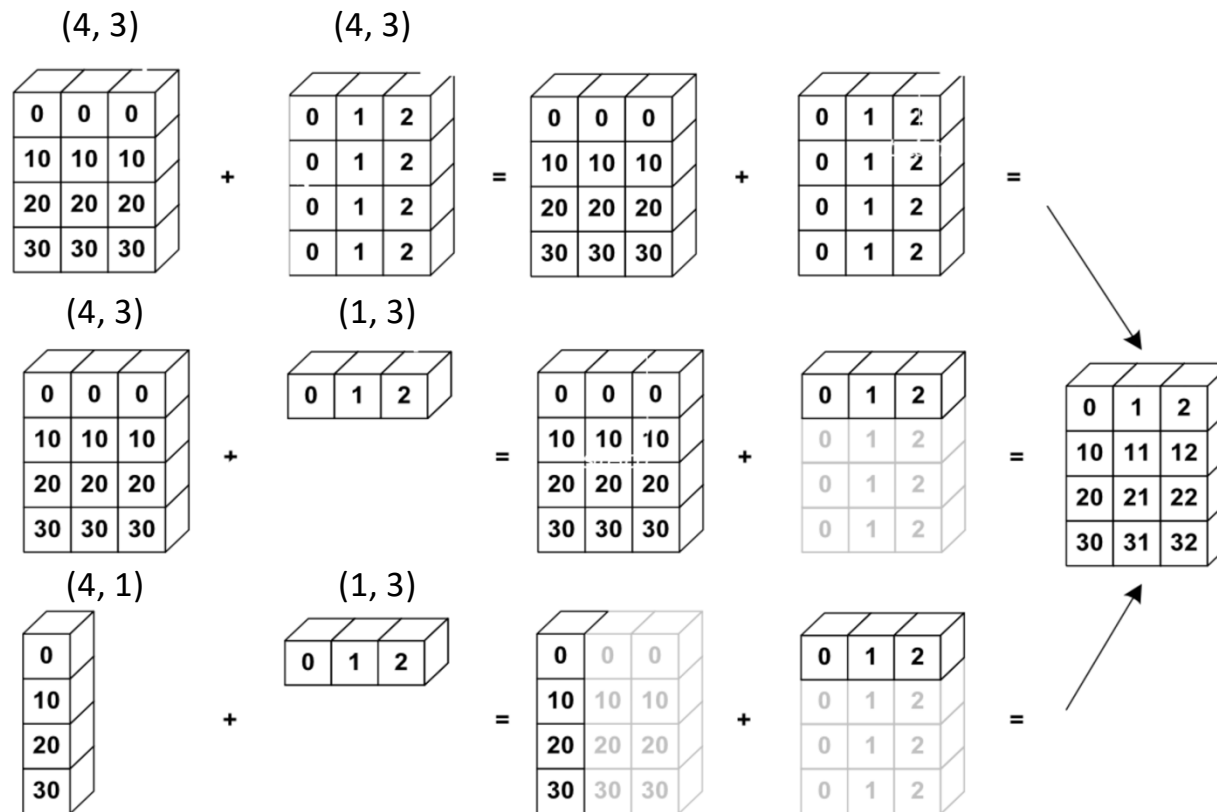
Up next: Tabular Data

Fancy indexing in NumPy – reference slide



`A[[2, 2, 1], [2, 0, 0]]`

Broadcasting matching rule: dimensions are aligned to the right and match if they are equal, or equal to 1



$(4, 3) + (4, 3) \rightarrow (4, 3)$

$(\mathbf{4}, 3) + (\mathbf{1}, 3) \rightarrow (\mathbf{4}, 3)$

$(\mathbf{4}, \mathbf{1}) + (\mathbf{1}, \mathbf{3}) \rightarrow (\mathbf{4}, \mathbf{3})$